The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AARON SCHWARTZ/POOL/EPA/Shutterstock

Donald Trump said **America** had hit more than 7,000 targets in **Iran** and “literally obliterated” the regime. He said America was ready to negotiate but that he had “no idea” who Iran’s leaders were, claiming they are all dead and that “nobody’s seen” Mojtaba Khamenei, Iran’s new supreme leader. Masoud Pezeshkian, Iran’s president, said it was “meaningless” to speak of ending the war until there were “no more attacks in our land”.

America’s president also denounced his allies for refusing his earlier request for assistance in reopening the Strait of Hormuz. Officials from **Germany, Italy,** and **Spain** have ruled out participating in military missions; **Australia**, **France** and **Japan** do not intend to send warships. **Britain’s** prime minister said he was pursuing a “viable plan” for the strait but would not be “drawn into the wider war”.

Mr Trump said he asked **China** to delay his much-anticipated meeting with Xi Jinping “because of the war” and needing to stay in Washington. Mr Trump had previously suggested suspending the summit after saying China should also “help” reopen the Strait of Hormuz. But on Monday Scott Bessent, America’s treasury secretary, said that any delay would be only because of “logistics”.

The **International Energy Agency**, an intergovernmental organisation, said it is prepared to release more oil reserves "if needed". Last week the IEA coordinated a record-breaking release of 400m barrels of **oil** from its strategic reserves. Since then oil prices have been steadily rising back up to around $100 per barrel. The 32 IEA members still have more than 1.4bn barrels of emergency stocks.

Cuba's electricity grid collapsed, leaving around 10m people without power. Its operator said it is investigating the cause. The island has suffered several outages in recent months; last week violent protests broke out in response to the blackouts. In January Mr Trump threatened to impose tariffs on any country that supplies Cuba with oil, which has deepened the crisis.

Structure Therapeutics, a biotech firm, released trial data showing its **weight-loss pill** appeared to rival market-leading competitors. Its shares rose by more than 5%. Patients in the study lost around 15% of their body weight in 44 weeks, beating results from Novo Nordisk and Eli Lilly. Pharmaceutical firms are racing to launch alternatives to injectable versions of the lucrative drugs.

Scientists may have discovered a new type of **planet**. Unlike other rocky or watery worlds, L 98-59 d, as it is known, contains "an ocean of magma" and a sulphurous atmosphere. Researchers used telescopes and computer simulations to map the formation of the molten planet, which is located roughly 35 light years from Earth. They said its conditions are unlikely to support life.

Figure of the day: 50%, the increase in the average size of illegal-waste sites in Britain in the decade to 2024. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

Europe braces for another energy shock

Europe has recently overcome one energy crisis but now another is upon it. After Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022 Europe began weaning itself off Russian fuel. It has replaced most of the Russian pipeline gas it was receiving with liquefied natural gas from America and the Middle East. Now the war in Iran is causing its price to soar. QatarEnergy, which makes a fifth of world's supply, has stopped production.

The European Union's energy ministers, who are meeting on Monday, have a choice of unpleasant alternatives: let high prices clobber their economies, restart coal-power stations or perhaps even reconsider the bloc's complete ban on imports of Russian gas, due to take effect next year. The crisis also adds urgency to the EU's push to modernise its electricity grids. The war strengthens the case for renewable energy, and for upgrading the infrastructure needed to distribute it. But that is a long-term solution. For now, Europe faces another painful energy squeeze.

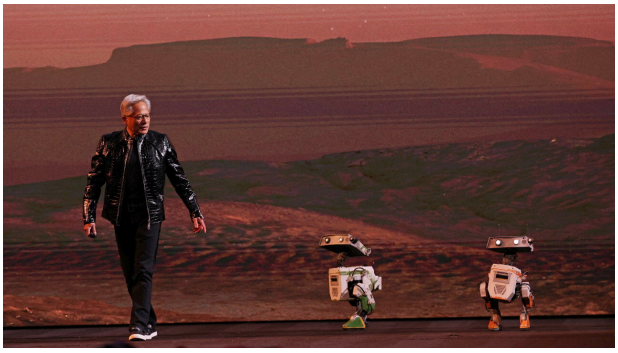
Photograph: Getty Images

Water could become a weapon in the Iran war

America's war against Iran, now in its third week, has caused the "largest supply disruption in history" to global oil markets, according to the International Energy Agency. For countries in the region, the threat to water supplies is as alarming.

Climate change has strained water resources across the arid Gulf: Qatar desalinates 99% of its drinking water; the United Arab Emirates roughly half. Iranian drones are capable of reaching the 400-plus desalination plants dotted along the Gulf coast.

Targeting such facilities is a war crime; Iran says that America did just that on March 7th. Bahrain claims that Iran hit one of its plants on the following day. Iran converts much less seawater than its neighbours, but may be more at risk: because of decades of poor management and an unprecedented drought Tehran, the capital, nearly ran dry last November.



Photograph: Getty Images

Nvidia defends its lead in the AI race

Nvidia's annual developer conference starts on Monday. The world's most valuable company is expected to unveil a chip designed specifically for "inference", the stage when artificial-intelligence models respond to users' queries. Until now AI firms have used Nvidia's graphics processors both to train models and to answer questions. Nvidia's development of a dedicated inference chip suggests that it now sees a growing market for specialised hardware.

The conference comes at a delicate moment. Investors are beginning to question how long the AI boom will last. On February 25th Nvidia reported record profits for the three months to January 25th, and forecast strong growth, yet its share price fell by more than 5% the next day. The company is also facing competition from its own customers. Large technology firms, including Google, Amazon and OpenAI, are developing their own AI chips to reduce their reliance on Nvidia. Jensen Huang, the firm's boss, will use his speech to reassure investors that Nvidia can stay ahead.

Photograph: Turkish Ministry of National Defence/AFP via Getty Images

Iran tests Turkey's patience

Turkey's government has opposed America's and Israel's war on Iran and has made clear it wants no part in it. Analysts have also assumed that Iran had no wish to draw in Turkey—a regional rival and a NATO member.

That assumption is being tested. Iran appears to have targeted NATO facilities inside Turkey. NATO defenses have already shot down three missiles headed for the country's airspace. The latest, on March 13th, was downed near the Incirlik airbase, which hosts Turkish, American and other NATO troops, judging by reports of sirens and explosions nearby. Iran has denied responsibility for the launches, but Turkey's foreign minister, Hakan Fidan, said that "technical data" contradict that claim. Turkey still wants to stay out of the war. But further attacks could force it to respond.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which character is portrayed by Sigourney Weaver in the Alien films?

There is always a third possibility, as long as you have the ability to find it.

Selma Lagerlöf